that these rulers abandon all thought of aggression, including against Ashoka's territory.[45]

The pattern seen above recurs with regard to people in Ashoka's own dominions: specifically mentioned are inhabitants of areas in the north-west, west, and towards the south. Among these were the Andhras: the populace at Erragudi may have seen this as a reference to them and, if so, one wonders if they agreed with their emperor's assessment that they were conforming to the morality that was now his mission. The Yavanas and other people who lived in the southern and north-western parts of the kingdom are similarly mentioned, possibly because Mauryan control over them was tenuous. That they are described not by an encompassing expression such as people ('jana') but in terms of their ethnogeographical identities means that Ashoka wanted to specify them as people who must, above all, conform to his dhamma. People in other parts of his empire are not mentioned because presumably they were known to have been or assumed to have been conforming in the required ways.

Such passages demonstrate an acknowledgement of the actual state of affairs within the Mauryan realm, the potential sources of instability. There is a similar acknowledgement now of what could realistically be expected by Ashoka of his successors. The 'dhammalipi' had been written so that his sons and grandsons would not think of fresh conquests. Yet, pragmatically accepting that conquest by his successors was very much in the realm of possibility, the emperor wished that they would be somewhat merciful in the event of victory in such warfare. 'In any victory they gained there should be mildness ("khamti") and light punishment ("lahudandata")', which as one scholar puts it, would make such conquest 'unlike his own victory, with its terrible consequences, in Kalinga.'[46]

In the end the king sets forth the range of variations in his records, and the reasons for the range. Since his dominions were wide, he says he has ensured that a great deal was written down, and more would be written in